

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1995-12-31

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 dearly loved friends,
2 in the wake of the dynamic spirit animating the six-day-long counselors'
3 conference at the world center, now in its final session as we address you,
4 we take the occasion to announce our decision which has been the subject
5 of their deliberations: At riḡv́n 1996 a global plan of expansion and con-
6 solidation will be launched, to end four years later at riḡv́n 2000.
7 it is this anticipation that has focused the thoughts of the seventy-eight
8 counselors from the five continents, who have been conferring together in the
presence of the hands of the cause of god Amatu'l-bahá rúḡyyih

khánúm, 'Alí-Akbar furútan and 'Alí-m uḡammad varqá, the members of

9 tional Teaching center. Their consultations on the challenges and prospects
10 facing the bahá'í world community have been of such caliber and content
11 as to have emboldened our expectations of a mighty thrust in the growth and
development of that community during the crucial years immediately ahead.

The whole plan will be announced at riḡv́n. however, we wish you to

12 have some information about it now within the measure of the discussions which
have been taking place at the counselors' conference.^{211.3}

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213 1993–1996 • The Three Year Plan

214 61The four year plan will aim at one major accomplishment: a significant
215 advance in the process of entry by troops. This is to be achieved through
216 marked progress in the activity and development of the individual believer,

217 of the institutions, and of the local community. keen attention to all three
 218 will ensure a greatly expanded, visibly united, vibrant and cohesive interna-tional
 community by the end of the twentieth century. The basic requisites
 219 can be summarized as follows.
 220 The first calls for a vitality of the faith of each believer that is expressed
 221 through personal initiative and constancy in teaching the cause to others,
 222 and through conscientious, individual effort to provide energy and resources to
 upbuild the community, to uphold the authority of its institutions, and to
 223 support local and regional plans and teaching projects. The second requires that local
 and national bahá'í institutions evolve more rapidly into a proper
 224 exercise of their responsibilities as channels of guidance, planners of the teaching
 work, developers of human resources, builders of communities, and loving shepherds of the
 multitudes. The third, the flourishing of the community especially at the local level, demands
 a significant enhancement
 225 in patterns of behavior by which the collective expression of the virtues of
 226 the individual members and the functioning of the Spiritual Assembly is manifest in
 the unity and fellowship of the community and the dynamism of its activity and growth.

Towards these ends, the work of the continental counselors must as-

227 sume new dimensions. Thus, at their conference, they have been deliberat-ing on
 such matters as:

– d evelopments in the mode of the functioning of the continental

228 boards of counselors.

– The process for the elaboration of the plan through the formulation

229 of derivative plans and strategies at the national, regional, and local

levels. joint consultations between the continental counselors and

230 National Spiritual Assemblies will begin immediately after riðván,

231 and the planning process will move quickly to the regional level,

involving Auxiliary board members, local Spiritual Assemblies

232 and committees.

233 – The development of human resources to meet the needs of a rap-idly expanding
 community. large-scale growth necessitates sus-

234 tained measures of consolidation. The urgent requirement is for formally conducted
 programs of training through institutes and other centers of learning, in the establishment
 and operation of 212.4

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213 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

62which the counselors and Auxiliary board members will become

214 more intimately involved.

– e f f e c t i v e a p p r o a c h e s t o t h e r a i s i n g u p a n d c o n s o l i d a t i o n o f l o c a l

Spiritual Assemblies. in accordance with the objective of fostering

the maturation of these Assemblies, a greater effort is required to

215 u p h o l d a v i t a l p r i n c i p l e , w h i c h i s t h a t t h e r e s p o n s i b i l i t y f o r e l e c t i n g

a local Spiritual Assembly rests primarily on the bahá'ís in the

locality. The Auxiliary board members and their assistants are to

increase their efforts to improve the general understanding of this

principle and will devote more attention to assisting the develop-

ment of local Assemblies. As of riḫván 1997, all local Spiritual

Assemblies throughout the world will have to be elected on the first

216 d a y o f r i ḫ v á n .

217 – f u r t h e r m e a n s f o r t h e d e v e l o p m e n t o f l o c a l b a h á ' í c o m m u n i t i e s .

The needs in this respect will be met in part by an immediate in-

crease in the membership of the Auxiliary boards for protection

to equal that of the Auxiliary boards for propagation, so that pro-

tection board members can directly and systematically assist on

218 a w i d e s c a l e t h e f u n d a m e n t a l a c t i v i t i e s o f t h e c o m m u n i t y , s u c h a s t h e s p i r i t u a l
n u r t u r i n g o f i n d i v i d u a l b e l i e v e r s , t h e p a r t i c i p a t i o n o f w o m e n i n a l l a s p e c t s o f c o m m u n i t y
l i f e , t h e o b s e r v a n c e o f t h e

Nineteen day feasts and holy days, the holding of children's

219 c l a s s e s , t h e f o s t e r i n g o f y o u t h a c t i v i t i e s .

220 The seven objectives specified in previous plans describe essential, in-
 221 teracting directions that must advance simultaneously into the foreseeable
 222 future. The four year plan's aim at accelerating the process of entry by
 223 troops identifies a necessity at this stage in the progress of the cause and
 224 in the state of human society. with this perspective, the three inseparable
 225 participants in the evolution of the new world order—the individual, the
 226 institutions, and the community—must now demonstrate more tangibly than ever
 before their capacity and willingness to embrace masses of new adherents, to effect the
 spiritual and administrative transformation of thou-
 227 sands upon thousands, and, above all, to multiply the army of knowledge-
 228 able, consecrated teachers of a faith whose emergence from obscurity must
 229 be registered on the consciousness of countless multitudes throughout the
 230 earth. These are among the detailed considerations that have occupied the
 231 deliberations of the continental counselors, who, upon their return home 212.6d
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 213 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n
 214 6and in the course of their work, will have occasion to share the results of
 215 their conference with the friends.
 216 An auspicious beginning for the new plan will largely depend on the re-
 217 sults of the current one, which will end in just a few months. The adequacy of these
 results will owe much to the degree to which the local Spiritual
 218 Assemblies and the friends carry out the directions of their National Spiri-
 219 tual Assemblies, the generals of every plan. Time is slipping away. This
 220 reality should prod us all to maximum action. hence, in preparation for
 221 what beckons us on the near horizon, we cannot, we must not, hesitate to
 222 expend every energy to bring the Three year plan to a successful conclusion.
 223 The urgency which intensifies our desire for such an outcome is not merely pride of
 victory, gratifying as that may be. There are divine deadlines to be met. o ur work is
 intended not only to increase the size and consolidate the
 224 foundations of our community, but more particularly to exert a positive influence on
 the affairs of the entire human race. At so crucial a moment in world affairs, we must not fail
 in our duty to take timely action on the goals set before us in the Three y ear p lan.

225 with the full fervor of our expectant hearts, we call upon you all, in-
226 dividually and collectively, to arise to the summons of the lord of hosts
227 to teach his cause. do so with love, faith and courage; and the doors of
228 heaven will open wide to pour forth benedictions upon your efforts.
229 with loving b ahá'í greetings,
230 213

Preparations for the Four Year Plan

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]